



IDEV

Independent Development Evaluation
Évaluation indépendante du développement

ESWATINI 2020-2024 CSP MID-TERM REVIEW VALIDATION NOTE



September 2023



AFRICAN DEVELOPMENT BANK GROUP

Acknowledgments

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Acronyms and Abbreviations

ADB	African Development Bank	MSME	Micro, Small and Medium Enterprise
AEO	African Economic Outlook	MTR	Mid-Term Review
AfDB	African Development Bank Group	MUA	Million Units of Account
BADEA	Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa	NDP	National Development Plan
CODE	Committee on Operations and Development Effectiveness	NDS	National Development Strategy
COVID-19	Coronavirus Disease 2019	OFID	OPEC Fund for International Development
CPIP	Country Portfolio Improvement Plan	PCR	Project Completion Report
CSP	Country Strategy Paper	PFM	Public Financial Management
CSPE	Country Strategy and Program Evaluation	PIP	Portfolio Improvement Plan
DCP	Development Cooperation Policy	PIU	Project Implementing Unit
EDCF	Eswatini Development Cooperation Forum	PPP	Public Private Partnership
ESW	Economic and Sector Work	RDGS	Regional Directorate General for Southern Africa
EU	European Union	RIMMP	Road Investment and Maintenance Management Program
IDEV	Independent Development Evaluation	RIS	Regional Integration Strategy
ICT	Information and Communication Technology	SERIG	Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program
IOP	Indicative Operational Program	SME	Small and Medium Enterprise
IPR	Implementation Progress and Results	SWG	Sector Working Group
LoC	Line of Credit	TAS	Treasury Accounting System
MDA	Ministries, Departments and Agencies	TYS	Ten-Year Strategy
MIC TAF	Middle Income Country - Technical Assistance Fund	UA	Unit of Account
		UN	United Nations
		ZAR	South African Rand

BASIC INFORMATION

BASIC CSP DATA			
a. Basic CSP Information			
Strategic focus: The aim of the CSP 2020-2024 is to support Eswatini’s economic recovery and develop a more resilient and diversified economy that can consistently deliver rapid, inclusive, and sustainable growth			
Pillar 1: Scaling Up Infrastructure Investments to Foster Economic Diversification	Sectors: Transport, Agriculture & Rural Development, Water & Sanitation		
Pillar 2: Strengthening Economic Governance to Improve the Investment Climate	Sectors: Multi-sector, Finance, Governance		
Country: Eswatini	Environmental categorization: Project categorisation ranges between Categories 1, 2, 3, and 4A		
Processing Milestones: N/A	Validity of Strategic focus: The CSP pillars have been maintained for the second phase of the CSP.		
Mid-term review: 04 October 2022 Team: Ms. L. F MOKADDEM, Director-General RDGS Mr. E. P. MOREIRA, Director, ECCE Mr. K. K. MBEKEANI, Deputy Director-General RDGS Mr. G. KARARACH, Lead Economist ECCE Mr. B. NYAJENA, Senior Economist ECCE Ms. I. CHORFI, Principal Country Program Officer, RDGS			Projects, interventions during cycle ¹ : Ongoing active projects: 13 Completed CSP projects: 2 Suspended projects: N/A
b. Resource Allocations			
Financing source/ instrument under CSP 2020-2024	Approved amount (MUA):	Disbursed amount (MUA):	Percentage disbursed (%):
Loans:	216.9	131.74	60.73%
Grants:	122	0.4	0.327%
GRAND TOTAL:	338.9	132.17	39.0%
Co-financiers and other external partners: AWF, MICTAF, CRIDF, BADEA, ADDF, KUWAIT FUND, OFID, EIB, World Bank			
c. Responsible Bank staff			
Position	At approval		At Mid-term
Regional Director	Ms. J. NGURE		Ms. L. F MOKADDEM
Lead Economist	Mr. G. HONDE		Mr. G. KARARACH
Country Economist	Mr. B. NYAJENA		Mr. B. NYAJENA
Country Program Officer	Mr. R. MWASAMBILI		Ms. I. CHORFI
d. Report data			
Validation Completion Date: March 2023			
Task Manager: Eric KERE Consultant: Jeannot NGOULMA		Peer Reviewers: Andrew ANGUKO and Girma KUMBI	

¹ At the time of preparing this validation (see Annex 1 and Annex 2).

1. OBJECTIVES OF THE ESWATINI CSP MTR VALIDATION

1.1. Objective and purpose of the validation

The purpose of this validation note is to provide the Committee on Operations and Development Effectiveness (CODE) and Bank Management with a credible, independent assessment of the mid-term review (MTR) report² of Eswatini's 2020-2024 Country Strategy Paper (CSP).³ This is done by examining the robustness of the evidence provided on the progress made at mid-term and assessing the status of implementation of agreed recommendations from the [Eswatini 2009-2018 CSP evaluation](#)⁴ by IDEV. Specifically, the objectives are to:

1. Assess the extent to which the mid-term objectives set at approval of the CSP were achieved, and the factors that enabled or hindered the implementation of the CSP, using the international development evaluation criteria.
2. Assess the level of implementation of agreed recommendations from the Eswatini 2009-2018 CSP evaluation by IDEV.
3. Provide an independent assessment of the quality of the MTR: to what extent does the MTR comply with the Bank's reporting requirements, and to what extent are the program's mid-term results based on evidence?
4. Draw lessons to inform the remainder of the implementation cycle of the Eswatini 2020-2024 CSP, to contribute to better development outcomes in the country.

This independent validation will be used to improve the quality of future reviews and the completion of the CSP.

1.2. Scope of the validation

The validation first reviews the progress made in the implementation of operations under the current CSP (2020-2024) at mid-term. This includes operations that were approved during the previous CSP cycle (2014-2018) and whose implementation continued during this CSP. The second aspect of the validation concerns all the African Development Bank Group (AfDB)'s activities, i.e., lending and non-lending (including grants and technical assistance), and examines the following main evaluation criteria: relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency and sustainability. The third aspect of the validation relates to the implementation of agreed actions in response to IDEV evaluation recommendations. The final aspect of the validation is the review of the relevance of the lessons identified in the MTR and the overall quality of the MTR report.

1.3. Limitations of the validation

The main limitation of the validation is inherent to any documentary review: the availability of strategy and project documents, and the comprehensiveness of the information. To address these limitations, the team conducted interviews with project task managers, the country economist, and the country program officer.

The second limitation is related to the fact that several operations in the portfolio were in the start-up phase or still being implemented. In this context, the validation examined the projects' potential for achieving the expected results, as well as their sustainability.

2. STRATEGIC ORIENTATIONS OF THE CSP 2020-2024

The Bank's 2020-2024 CSP for the Kingdom of Eswatini is largely based on the guidelines set by government authorities concerning the priority development areas, but also on the Bank's operational priorities and flagship initiatives.

² ADB/BD/WP/2022/189/Approved.

³ ADB/BD/WP/2020/13/Rev.1/Approved.

⁴ ADB/BD/WP/2019/65

2.1. Objective and strategic orientation of the CSP

The overall objective of the Bank's CSP 2020-2024 for Eswatini is to support the country's economic recovery and to develop a more resilient and diversified economy that can consistently deliver rapid, inclusive, and sustainable growth. The CSP 2020-2024 has two priority areas, denominated as follows:

- ***Priority Area I - Scaling-Up Infrastructure Investments to Foster Economic Diversification***

The main objective of Priority Area I is to support the expansion of growth-enhancing and catalytic infrastructure to remove structural bottlenecks, enable economic diversification, and reduce the cost of doing business. It aims to provide critical stimulus for economic development, as well as improve the availability of socio-economic opportunities for boosting productive capacities. Furthermore, the Bank's support under Priority Area I aims to contribute to rapid diversification of the country's economic base. Targeted infrastructure interventions in Priority Area I will also serve as a foundation for promoting the country's investment climate under Priority Area II.

- ***Priority Area II - Strengthening Economic Governance to Improve the Investment Climate***

The main objective of Priority Area II is to galvanize reforms aimed at strengthening economic governance, promoting private sector development and improving the investment climate. The Bank's interventions aim to improve the macroeconomic framework, public sector performance, the efficient use of resources, and human capital and skills development for job creation. The priority investment areas are: (i) strengthening public financial management (PFM), the budget process, and fiscal consolidation; (ii) expanding access to finance for the private sector, particularly small and medium enterprises (SMEs); (iii) supporting the development of the public-private partnership (PPP) framework; and (iv) contributing to addressing skills gaps in the growth sectors targeted under Priority Area I. Under Priority Area II, the Bank intends to continue the dialogue on the application of policy-based operations (PBOs) and to use private sector financing instruments, engagement on policy reforms, technical assistance, and economic and sector work (ESW) to enhance the participation of the private sector in the economy. This support aims to improve the business environment and strengthen private sector participation in economic development and to contribute to diversification efforts.

Finally, the Eswatini CSP 2020-2024 planned to mainstream cross-cutting issues of green growth, climate change, gender and youth employment. In non-lending activities, the Bank planned to support the country with informative and well-focused knowledge products and analytical policy briefs to inform policy dialogue. The identification of growth drivers for economic diversification and the country's comparative advantages were the priorities. Feasibility studies to stimulate agricultural production, investment, private sector and PPP development, and renewable energy were also planned. The envisaged investor roadmap sought to identify opportunities for increased value-added industries. The Bank was also planning to undertake a gender profile for Eswatini, as part of a regional gender profile study.

2.2. Portfolio status at mid-term

As of 31 August 2022 (cut-off date for the MTR), the Bank Group's active portfolio had 12 operations, including eight projects, one line of credit, one study and two technical assistance projects. The value of the portfolio had increased from UA 170.48 million in 2020 to UA 338.9 million in 2022. The average size of investment projects had also increased significantly from UA 18.9 million in 2020 to more than UA 34 million in 2022. The portfolio was financed mainly through African Development Bank (ADB) resources. Eswatini also benefited from Middle Income Country Technical Assistance Fund (MIC TAF) resources. The portfolio covered five sectors: agriculture accounted for 56.4 percent of resources, followed by transport (17.6 percent), water and sanitation (14.8 percent), multi-sector (8.2 percent) and finance (3 percent).

The average age of the portfolio was 3.3 years, with a disbursement rate of 39.0 percent. There were two aging projects (the Manzini-Mbadlane Highway Project and the Ezulwini Sustainable Water and Sanitation Service Delivery), both due to close in 2022. The outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic in early 2020, and the resulting lockdowns and travel restrictions, negatively impacted the physical supervision of projects, which delayed the implementation of the 2019 Country Portfolio Improvement Plan (CPIP).

The 2019 CPIP,⁵ agreed during the preparation of the CSP 2020-2024, noted several issues requiring the attention of both the Bank and the Government. In the annex to the MTR, the summary of the 2019 CPIP noted 17 actions to be undertaken in total. Of these 17, 11 were implemented, four were partly implemented and two were not implemented at the time of the MTR. This progress has been achieved through regular interactions between the Bank and the Government. During the preparation of the MTR, a CPIP 2022⁶ was agreed between the Bank, the Government, and project implementing units (PIUs) for implementation to closely monitor and address all the portfolio challenges.

3. VALIDATION OF RESULTS ACHIEVED AT MID-TERM

The validation is based on the theory of change (see Annex 3) that underpinned the Bank's assistance strategies during the period under review. International evaluation criteria (relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency and sustainability) are applied and a four-point rating scale⁷ has been used to assess each of the evaluation criteria. For details, see Annex 4.

The validation was based on the CSP 2020-2024 project results framework matrix, the MTR report of the CSP, a review of project documents (Appraisal Reports, Implementation Progress and Results Reports, and Project Completion Reports), and consultations and interviews with task managers and the Eswatini country team. In this validation, most of the projects with significant progress were approved during the previous CSP (2014-2018), but ongoing or completed during the CSP period (2020-2024) under review.

3.1. Relevance

The extent to which the CSP and its pillars are relevant for the country's development priorities, as well as its alignment with the Bank's operational priorities.

The MTR validation rates the relevance of the CSP as satisfactory. The Bank's strategic orientation through its CSP 2020-2024 for Eswatini was found to be well aligned with the country's development priorities and strategy, and the Bank's strategies and priorities. Indeed, the CSP has been designed to address Eswatini's development challenges: infrastructure gaps in agriculture, transport, water and sanitation, and energy, and a non-conducive environment for business development. This strategic orientation of the Bank's CSP remains relevant because Eswatini's needs are unchanged and were exacerbated by the COVID-19 pandemic, together with global geopolitical and domestic tensions.

The CSP's two Priority Areas, *Scaling-Up Infrastructure Investments to Foster Economic Diversification* and *Strengthening Economic Governance to Improve the Investment Climate*, are aligned with the Bank's Ten-Year Strategy (TYS) 2013-2022 and the High 5 priorities, which are "Light Up and Power Africa," "Feed Africa," "Industrialize Africa," "Integrate Africa," and "Improve the Quality of Life for the People of Africa." Moreover, the operations approved in all sectors are also aligned with Eswatini's priorities, the Bank's TYS 2013-2022, sector strategies, the High 5s and the Bank's Regional Integration Strategy (RIS 2014-2023) for the Southern Africa region.

The strategy was found to be consistent with the Government's priorities as detailed in the National Development Plan 2019-2022 (NDP 2019-2022), and the draft new NDP (2023-2027), which seeks to place the country on a higher, sustained, and inclusive growth trajectory. The pillars and the approved operations of the current and previous strategies are still, and remain, relevant in all sectors. Through the CSP Priority Area I, the Bank supports the expansion of growth-enhancing and catalytic infrastructure to remove structural bottlenecks, enable economic diversification, and reduce the cost of doing business. For instance, the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program (MNWAP: study, Phase 1A and Phase 1B) aims to contribute to food security, poverty reduction and resilience to climate change, through supporting water and irrigation infrastructure development, special agro-processing activities and parallel development in transport, energy and urban development. Priority Area II, "Strengthening Economic Governance to Improve the Investment Climate", is directly aligned with the NDP 2019-2022 and the Strategic Roadmap for Economic Recovery (2019-2022) of Eswatini. The objective of Priority Area II is to drive reforms aimed at strengthening economic governance, promoting private sector development and improving the investment climate. For example, the "Support for

⁵ ADB/BD/WP/2019/152 - ADF/BD/WP/2019/102.

⁶ ADB/BD/WP/2022/189/Approved - ADF/BD/WP/2022/142/Approved.

⁷ The four-point ratings are: 1. Unsatisfactory; 2. Partly unsatisfactory; 3. Satisfactory; and 4. Highly satisfactory.

Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program (SERIG) Phase I" is focused on attaining fiscal consolidation, creating a conducive environment for a vibrant employment-generating private sector, improving livelihoods, and expanding social protection for inclusive growth.

Relevance of CSP design: The design of the CSP is considered satisfactory by the validation due to the consultations that were carried out during its preparation, the presence of reference/baseline data for all the results indicators of the program's logical framework, a clear definition of the results chain, and satisfactory analysis of risks and mitigation measures. However, the absence of mid-term targets for the expected results makes mid-term evaluation difficult.

3.2. Coherence

The extent to which the CSP interventions were coherent with other interventions of the Bank, as well as coherent with strategies and interventions of other development partners.

The validation rates the coherence of the Bank's interventions as satisfactory.

Internal coherence and synergy. The coherence of the Bank's portfolio of activities in Eswatini is considered as satisfactory. The CSP 2020-2024 Priority Areas were closely coherent with the National Development Strategy (NDS 1997-2022), as well as the Bank's High 5's and TYS. The choice of intervention areas was informed by Eswatini's development priorities as articulated in the NDP 2019-2022 and the Strategic Roadmap for Economic Recovery (2019-2022), both of which support the NDS. The NDS, implemented through short- to medium-term development plans, is Eswatini's overarching long-term planning framework for the period 1997-2022. The NDP and the Strategic Roadmap for Economic Recovery articulate the country's medium-term development plans for the period 2019-2022.

The current articulation of the Bank's interventions around the MNWAP program (MNWAP study; MNWAP-1A; and MNWAP-2A) has made it possible to develop a strong synergy between the sectors. Indeed, operations under Priority Area I are expected to provide water and irrigation infrastructure development, special agro-processing, and parallel development in transport, energy and urban development. For instance, the projects in the transport sector promote the supply of raw materials to the agro-processing zone and the delivery of finished products to consumption centers. Priority Area II aims to promote the development of the private sector through the improvement of economic governance, including the investment climate and the provision of more financing opportunities for SMEs. However, the Bank would need to ensure that the lines of credit being implemented can also benefit eligible enterprises in the agro-industrial zone.

External coherence and leverage. The Bank's strategy and intervention programs in Eswatini were also found to be coherent with those of other development partners, particularly in the sectors of economic governance (European Union [EU], UN agencies), infrastructure (OPEC Fund for International Development [OFID]), water and sanitation (EU, World Bank), agriculture (EU, UN agencies), and multi-sector (EU, UN agencies). It is important to mention that at the country level several development partners are present and intervene in other areas, such as education, health, energy, information and communication technology (ICT), climate change, social protection, trade, etc. Eswatini's Development Cooperation Policy (DCP), launched in 2020, provides the framework for donor coordination and ensures the advancement of the principles of the Paris Declaration (2005), the Accra Agenda for Action (2008) and the Busan Partnership agreement (2011). The DCP provides aid coordination implementation arrangements, including the establishment of the Eswatini Development Cooperation Forum (EDCF) and Sector Working Groups (SWGs). Operationalization of the DCP is ongoing. Under the CSP, the Bank continued to sustain dialogue and coordination with other development partners to obtain co-financing arrangements for Bank-financed projects/programs in Eswatini.

The Bank was also found to maintain a leading position as partner of choice in agriculture, transport, water and sanitation, and PFM, and has engaged with development partners to foster strong collaboration in project implementation. Development partners, including OFID and the EU, have expressed interest in co-financing projects in the agriculture, water and sanitation, and energy sectors. The Bank continued to promote deeper dialogue, including through enhanced participation in SWGs, in sectors in which it has a strong presence. The opening of a Bank Liaison Office in September 2022 is expected to continue to further strengthen cooperation and policy dialogue with Eswatini. During the remaining CSP period, the Bank intends to pursue its holistic integrated development approach to strengthen synergies between Bank-financed projects across sectors to maximize project achievements.

3.3. Effectiveness

The extent to which the expected results at mid-term were achieved as planned. Which factors enabled or hindered the smooth implementation of the CSP?

The validation is based on information collected in March 2023. It also presents the progress made between September and March 2023.

The MTR validation rates effectiveness as partly unsatisfactory, despite progress in achieving results compared with the findings of the last IDEV country strategy and program evaluation in 2019. Conclusive results have been observed but are deemed insufficient to achieve the objectives set by the CSP. The CSP envisages 11 outputs and 11 outcomes to be achieved at completion under both Priority Areas combined. At mid-term, five outputs (45 percent) and four outcomes (36 percent) had either been achieved or partly achieved with substantial progress. However, the scope of some projects has been reduced due to design problems, thus compromising the achievement of the initial results. Also, the delays in the approval and implementation of the indicative program of the CSP are such that the expected results are unlikely to be achieved by 2024. This lagging performance is partly explained by the negative shocks that have affected the country over the first half of the CSP period: weak growth of the South African economy (on which Eswatini is heavily dependent), the COVID-19 pandemic, the 2021 Tropical Cyclone Eloise, the 2021 civil unrest, and Russia's invasion of Ukraine.⁸

The pace of approval of operations planned under the CSP (2020-2024) was found to be below expectations. Indeed, only two projects were approved at mid-term out of the eight planned in the Indicative Operational Program (IOP): (i) the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase 1A (UA 126.2 million), under Priority Area I, approved as planned at mid-term; and (ii) Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program Phase 1 (UA 27.6 million) under Priority Area II, initially planned in the second half of the CSP. In addition, one unplanned operation, the Eswatini Emergency Food Production Program (UA 30 million) was approved in July 2022 within the framework of the African Emergency Food Production Facility (AEFPF). Regarding the non-lending program, as of August 2022, only one operation (MIC TAF grant to support Mkondvo-Ngwavuma Feasibility [UA 1.2 million]) out of the planned four operations was approved. However, two unplanned operations were approved: (i) Support to State Owned Enterprises Reforms in Eswatini; and (ii) Public Procurement Technical Assistance (UA 110 000). The projects of the current CSP are mostly at commencement phase with no activities started yet as they have been recently approved. The validation's assessment of the effectiveness criterion therefore mainly concerns the projects from the previous CSPs, and assesses progress on the achievement of expected outputs and outcomes as at March 2023.

Priority Area I - Scaling-Up Infrastructure Investments to Foster Economic Diversification.

With a difficult international context due to the COVID-19 pandemic, achievements in several sectors of Priority Area I have been delayed. This Priority Area encompasses the transport, water and sanitation, and agriculture and rural development sectors.

Expected Result 1: Expanded and strengthened infrastructure that promotes diversification, and inclusive and sustainable growth.

Transport. There are two projects ongoing in the transport sector: (i) the Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway Project; and the (ii) Development of Manzini Golf Course Interchange project. Overall, transport sector projects have only managed to build 34 km of roads out of a target of 304 km initially planned in the CSP 2020-2024, and the project to improve 40 km of railway (Swazi Rail Link Project) has not yet started due to a change in the government's priorities.

As regards the "Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway Project" approved in 2014 (during the CSP 2014-2018), the main objective was to improve regional interconnectivity, increase trade flows, generate revenue for the country and thus reduce poverty. The project has reduced the average travel time between home and work by minibus from 45 to 30 minutes against an initial target of 32 minutes. The number of road accident fatalities has also been reduced from 22 to 10 per year in line with the initial target. With regard to the increase in road traffic and the improvement of mobility, the targets are expected to be achieved as traffic recovers to pre-COVID-19 levels and the anticipated growth in road

⁸ Language adopted in the Communiqué of the Board of Governors at the AfDB Annual Meetings in May 2022; Algeria, China, Egypt, Eswatini, Namibia, Nigeria and South Africa entered a reservation and proposed "Russia-Ukraine Conflict".

traffic. In terms of outputs, eight out of nine have been 100 percent achieved. Only maintenance and capacity-building activities remain for the project to be completed.

The "Development of Manzini Golf Course Interchange project" was approved in 2018. The objective was to support the country's growth through investing in safe, efficient and cost-effective transport systems that contribute to improving regional trade connectivity and improve mobility in the urban areas, thereby opening up opportunities for economic activities, and access to social and economic services and jobs. The major civil engineering works have reached a 92 percent completion rate, but the interchange—essential for the road to be functional—is not yet finished. The outcomes can only be achieved once the interchange is completed. For example, the weighted average journey time has so far gone from 80 to 60 seconds against a target of 10 seconds.

Agriculture. There are five projects in the agriculture and rural development sector in the Eswatini portfolio: (i) the Lower Usuthu Smallholders Irrigation Project II; (ii) the Emergency Food Production Program (EFPP); and a comprehensive program of three projects, including (iii) the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program (MNWAP) Study; (iv) the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase 1A (MNWAP-1A); and (v) the Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase 1B (MNWAP-1B). In this sector, 39 km of main conveyance system have been constructed (100 percent of the target) and two agricultural value chains are still to be developed.

The "Lower Usuthu Smallholder Irrigation Project II" was approved in 2016. The objective was to increase household income, enhance food security, and improve access to social and health infrastructure for the rural population by creating the conditions for the transformation of subsistence-level smallholder farmers into small-scale commercial farmers. The main outcome (increased crop production) of this project was 100 percent achieved. Indeed, as expected, the production of crops such as sugar cane, banana, maize, and sugar bean increased from 0 mt to 440,000 mt, 14,790 mt, 5,792 mt, and 1,622 mt, respectively. This was possible thanks to the construction of the main transport system (39 km) by the AfDB and the other components of the project funded by the European Investment Bank and the Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa (BADEA).

Concerning the "Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program", the overall goal of this program is to contribute to food security, poverty reduction, and resilience to climate change, through supporting water and irrigation infrastructure development in Eswatini. Of the three projects (MNWAP study, MNWAP-1A, MNWAP-1B) included in the program, only the study (approved in 2020) has made significant progress. It prepared the approval of the MNWAP-1A (approved in December 2021) and MNWAP-1B (approved in December 2022), projects that have not yet started.

The "Emergency Food Production Program (EFPP)" was approved in July 2022, and its implementation started in August 2022 with the National Maize Subsidy Programme. The EFPP's purpose is to boost Eswatini's agricultural production and productivity to build the resilience of food systems and mitigate risks to food supply in the short to medium term.

Water and sanitation. There are four projects in the water and sanitation sector: (i) the Mbabane Manzini corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam study; (ii) the Mbabane Manzini corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam; (iii) the Ezulwini Sustainable Water Supply and Sanitation Service Delivery Project; and (iv) the Manzini Region Water Supply and Sanitation Project. Overall, 15 km (100 percent of the target) of gravity pipeline delivering potable water to the Ezulwini area and 78 km of sanitation pipeline (out of 65 km planned) have been completed. This infrastructure has made it possible to improve the supply of drinking water from 30 to 71 percent (100 percent of the target) and access to sanitation from 0 to 64 percent (for a target of 50 percent).

The "Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam study" and "Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam" study were both approved in 2015; their objective is to mobilize the necessary financing for the projects that will be identified. The projects are complementary and have the same results matrix. The "Mbabane Manzini Corridor multipurpose dam study" made it possible to prepare the blueprint for the socio-economic development of the study area, environmental and social impact studies, assessment of resilience to climate change, etc. The objective is to increase the availability of water for multiple uses. The second project, the "Mbabane Manzini Corridor Multipurpose Dam" study, identified and prepared the feasibility study and detailed design of the multipurpose storage dam to supply the Mbabane Manzini urban corridor, intended to provide water for irrigating 800 ha of land and produce hydropower. The level of completion of the studies made it possible to reach 75 percent of the financial close of the project (percentage of financing pledged). As mentioned in the last IPR and the PCR, "the outcome is likely to be achieved by end of the project. Application for sector financing by the government of Eswatini to the African Development Bank is underway with the

Government indicating that it will propose a funding mix of both grant climate funds and loans to meet the funding requirements for this project". In addition, six out of seven outputs were 100 percent achieved. Only the "Project Financing options report, including PPP and financing strategy" is not achieved due to funding constraints under this sub-component. Some elements of the financing were analyzed and reported in the technical feasibility study.

As regards the "Ezulwini Sustainable Water Supply and Sanitation Service Delivery Project" approved in 2014, the purpose was to support the development of the Ezulwini Municipality by addressing the constraints related to water and sanitation service provision, and improving the health and livelihood of the residents of Ezulwini and surrounding areas. One out of three activities of the main outcome (Improved access to reliable and sustainable water supply system in Ezulwini and surrounding areas) has been 100 percent achieved, while the two other activities have respective progress rates of 32 percent (Proportion of people with access to safe and reliable water supply in the project area) and 72 percent (Proportion of people with access to a sewerage system in the project area). Regarding the outputs, all the activities of component 3 (institutional support and capacity building, and project management) and component 2 (sanitation) have been 100 percent completed, except one activity (sewer connection), which is currently at 71 percent completion: 630 sewer connections were made out of 844 planned. The activities of component 1 (water supply infrastructure) have an average progress rate of 75 percent. Some activities of this component (intake works; water treatment plant; raw water gravity main) have been removed from the design of the project due to changes in government priorities since the approval of the project.

Regarding the "Manzini Region Water Supply and Sanitation Project" approved in 2018, the objective was to meet drinking water needs of Manzini and surrounding areas, and reduce the risk of environmental pollution of the groundwater through provision of appropriate sanitation services. One (improved performance of Eswatini Water Services Corporation) out of four outcomes has been achieved. Regarding the outputs, the activities of component 1 (water supply infrastructure) are not implemented and those of component 2 (sanitation) were cancelled due to design problems (an increase in the cost of materials in foreign currencies for a project design in local currency). On component 3 (institutional support and project management), five out of seven planned activities were carried out at 100 percent. The two remaining activities (guidelines for mainstreaming gender in water supply and sanitation, and internships for female engineers/technicians) have not yet started. It should be noted that this project had many problems related to procurement, procedures, and design, etc.

Priority Area II - Strengthening Economic Governance to Improve the Investment Climate.

This Priority Area includes: (i) the multi-sector, such as the economic governance sector; and (ii) the finance sector. Many projects in this Priority Area have not yet started, because they have only recently been approved in 2022. Overall, the fiscal adjustment strategy and action plan (FAP) 2021-2023 has been adopted and the implementation of the domestic arrears strategy is ongoing. However, the PFM Roadmap and the PPP policy and legislative framework are not yet implemented.

Expected Result 2: Improved public financial management and fiscal sustainability

To assess progress on this key expected result, the evaluation only reviewed the: (i) Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program (SERIG) Phase I project, because the other projects, such as (ii) the Public Procurement Technical Assistance, approved in July 2022; and (iii) the Support to State-owned Enterprises Reforms in Eswatini, approved in June 2022, have not yet started their activities.

The "Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program (SERIG) Phase I", a program-based operation (PBO) approved in November 2021 with an objective to enhance economic governance, improve the investment climate, and increase social protection for inclusive growth and accelerated post-COVID-19 recovery, is demonstrating slow progress. Only one out of seven activities related to the outcome has been 100 percent achieved. Three out of seven activities have a 0 percent progress rate (Number of sectors benefiting from increase in minimum wage; Global Competitiveness Index; Percentage of open tenders to total procurement). The three other activities have average progress rates of 80 percent. Concerning the outputs, seven out of 14 have been achieved at 100 percent, and the rest are in progress, except the activity 'PFM Regulations approved' which has not been approved by the Eswatini parliament. Discussions were underway with the government for the financing of a second phase of the PBO, with a view to helping to consolidate the achievements of the program.

Expected Result 3: Enhanced investment climate conducive for private sector growth

This key result concerns the "Development Finance Corporation (FINCORP) - Second LoC under the Africa SME Program", which is a line of credit (LoC) approved in May 2017, with an expected completion date in January 2028. The primary objective of the Fincorp is to promote the diversification of the economy, the private sector, job creation and poverty alleviation through support to Swazi-owned SMEs. The COVID-19 pandemic, Russia's invasion of Ukraine, and the political unrest in the country all negatively affected the implementation of the project and the balance sheet of the Fincorp. The Fincorp, with the Bank's support, has implemented mitigation measures that have improved its financial situation. The Bank has also promoted reforms in the financial sector. Thus far, the project is fully disbursed (total of UA 17.4 million, in two tranches) and 80 out of the targeted 305 SMEs have received funding - 30 in sugarcane farming, 31 in the heavy haulage business mostly providing heavy haulage services to the sugar industry, and the rest in other sectors. The project has already made it possible to increase: (i) the value of loans granted to SMEs; (ii) the number of SMEs accessing funding from the Fincorp; and (iii) taxes paid to the Government. Furthermore, the LoC created up to 1,498 jobs - 769 for women and 267 for youth. The final achievement of the targeted results can only be observed at the end of the project in 2028.

3.4. Efficiency

The extent to which the CSP interventions were efficiently implemented according to time schedules and budgets.

The validation assesses the efficiency of AfDB interventions in Eswatini as partly unsatisfactory. Interventions were found to suffer from implementation delays, including those due to unpredictable factors such as the COVID-19 pandemic. Nevertheless, there is progress compared with the findings of the IDEV evaluation in 2019.

Timeliness

The implementation of the Bank's projects in Eswatini between 2020 and 2022 has experienced delays due to several factors, such as: (i) the COVID-19 pandemic, due to the lockdowns and destabilization of supply chains; (ii) the 2021 Tropical Cyclone Eloise; (iii) the 2021 civil unrest; (iv) difficulties in project start-up; (v) quality at entry and project design: modification of the initial design of projects due to new government priorities or to take into account the requirements of parliament; (v) problems related to procurement; (vi) delays in disbursements; (viii) inflation, which has increased the costs for projects funded in local currencies; and (ix) the lengthy loan agreements ratification process. Table 1 below summarizes the deadlines for implementation per project from the approval to the expected date of completion.

Seven projects out of 15 experienced closure date extensions. For instance, for the "Ezulwini Sustainable Water Supply and Sanitation Service Delivery Project", the first disbursement took place 12 months after approval, and the closing date has already been postponed twice (2020 and 2022) and is likely to experience a third postponement because the project is not yet completed. In the transport sector, the first disbursement of the "Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway Project" took place 15 months after the approval date and project completion was postponed to 2022, but the project is still in process. These timelines are well beyond the limits set in AfDB Presidential Directive 02/2015, which prescribes that time elapsed from project approval to effectiveness should be no more than 3 months, and 6 months to first disbursement. The main reasons for the delays are changes in project designs and the low capacity of contractors.

Implementation Progress

Despite the challenges encountered during the implementation of the CSP, the overall performance of the Bank's ongoing portfolio in Eswatini is rated as satisfactory by the MTR, with an average rating of 3 out of 4. This rating is deemed appropriate by the validation, taking into account the prevailing context. Compared with IDEV's evaluation in 2019, significant progress can be noted.

Most of the projects in the portfolio approved during the CSP 2014-2018 have high disbursement rates, sometimes around 88 percent, such as the "Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway" or the "Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam" project with 86 percent disbursement rates. However, the "Manzini Region Water Supply and Sanitation Project" has a disbursement rate of 1.5 percent and has not seen significant progress so far. The delays in the implementation of this project are mainly related

to the quality at entry and the design of the project in local currency. With inflation leading to an increase in the price of materials, the scope of the project had to be reduced.

Table 1: Implementation deadlines, by project

Project	Approval date	First disbursement	Expected completion date (first)	Expected completion date (second)	CSP
Transport					
Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway Project -ADB (project loan) -ADB-MIC (Technical Assistance Grant)	May 2014	July 2015 June 2015	June 2018	June 2022	CSP 2014-2018
Development of Manzini Golf Course Interchange	Oct. 2018	Oct. 2019	Dec. 2022	June 2023	CSP 2014-2018
Agriculture					
Lower Usuthu Smallholders Irrigation Project II	May 2016	April 2017	Dec. 2021	Dec. 2024	CSP 2014-2018
Mkondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program (MNWAP) Study	March 2020	June 2020	Sept. 2022		CSP 2020-2024
Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase IA (MNWAP-1A)	Dec.2021		Dec. 2028		CSP 2020-2024
Emergency Food Production Program (EFPP)	July 2022		Sept. 2023		CSP 2020-2024
Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase 1B (MNWAP-1B)	Dec. 2022		June 2031		CSP 2020-2024
Water and sanitation					
Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam study	Dec. 2015	March 2016	Dec. 2020	Dec. 2022	CSP 2014-2018
Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam	Dec. 2015	April 2016	Dec. 2020	Dec.2021	CSP 2014-2018
Ezulwini Sustainable Water Supply and Sanitation Service Delivery Project	June 2014	May 2015	June 2018	Dec. 2020 & 2022	CSP 2014-2018
Manzini Region Water Supply and Sanitation Project	Nov. 2018	March 2020	Dec. 2022	Dec. 2023	CSP 2014-2018
Multi-sector					
Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program (SERIG) Phase I	Nov. 2021	April 2022	Oct. 2022	March 2023	CSP 2020-2024
Public Procurement Technical Assistance	July 2022		June 2024		CSP 2020-2024
Support to state owned enterprises reforms in Eswatini	June 2022		Nov. 2023	July 2024	CSP 2020-2024
Finance					
Development Finance Corporation (FINCORP) - Second LoC	May 2017	May 2019	Jan. 2028		CSP 2014-2018

Table 2: Disbursement rate per project (as of March 2023)

Project	Disbursement rate (%)	CSP
Transport		
Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway Project	88.15	CSP 2014-2018
Development of Manzini Golf Course Interchange	65.3	CSP 2014-2018
Agriculture		
Lower Usuthu Smallholders Irrigation Project II	82.6	CSP 2014-2018
Mkondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program (MNWAP) Study	44.3	CSP 2020-2024
Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase IA (MNWAP-1A)	0	CSP 2020-2024
Emergency Food Production Program (EFPP)	100	CSP 2020-2024
Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase 1B (MNWAP-1B)	0	CSP 2020-2024
Water and sanitation		
Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam study	82.23	CSP 2014-2018
Mbabane Manzini Corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam	86.03	CSP 2014-2018
Ezulwini Sustainable Water Supply and Sanitation Service Delivery Project	85.2	CSP 2014-2018

Manzini Region Water Supply and Sanitation Project	1.5	CSP 2014-2018
Multi-sector		
Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program (SERIG) Phase I	100	CSP 2020-2024
Public Procurement Technical Assistance	0	CSP 2020-2024
Support to state owned enterprises reforms in Eswatini	0	CSP 2020-2024
Finance		
Development Finance Corporation (FINCORP)-Second LoC	100	CSP 2014-2018

Most of the projects approved during the CSP 2020-2024 have not yet experienced any disbursement. The few operations with high disbursement rates under this CSP are either studies, PBOs or LoCs: the "Mkondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program (MNWAP) Study" with a disbursement rate of 44.3 percent, the "Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth Program (SERIG) Phase I", a PBO with a disbursement rate of 100 percent, the "Emergency Food Production Program (EFPP)" with a disbursement rate of 100 percent, and the "Development Finance Corporation (FINCORP) - Second LoC", a line of credit with a disbursement rate of 100 percent.

3.5. Sustainability

The extent to which the CSP's and project benefits are likely to be sustained in the long term.

The (likelihood of) sustainability is assessed as satisfactory. The sustainability of Bank interventions was found by the validation to have been strengthened over time due to the collaboration between the Government and the Bank. However, as most projects are in their initial phase or have not yet been completed, the planned actions have not yet been fully implemented. If they are well implemented, tangible results are likely to be observed. In the transport sector, for example, several reforms have been undertaken with the support of the Bank, including the transformation and operationalization of the Road Maintenance Fund. The Government is also working on a 10-year Road Investment and Maintenance Management Program (RIMMP) to strengthen asset preservation, guided by the country's Transport Master Plan (2013-2032). The Road Investment and Maintenance Management Program will provide a framework for addressing strategic lapses in investment and maintenance, notwithstanding the expected outcomes of the reform process that are intended to address other systemic sector challenges. In the agriculture sector, there are plans to create an agricultural fund to support the sustainability of agricultural projects. Currently, most of the projects of the CSP 2020-2024 also plan training and capacity building in their component activities. Finally, ongoing reforms in the governance sector also intend to strengthen the economic, social and institutional sustainability of projects.

3.6. Cross-Cutting Issues

For the cross-cutting issues, the validation found that a number of relevant actions are planned, but their results can only be assessed when they are fully implemented. For example, during the remaining CSP period, the Bank planned to provide technical assistance to assist the Government in finalizing and operationalizing its gender policy, including: (i) the development of a framework for gender-responsive budgeting; (ii) the establishment of a national coordination mechanism for the implementation of the gender policy; and (iii) the development of a monitoring framework for the gender policy across all sectors. The Bank also planned to support efforts in climate change and disaster risk management by enhancing the capacity of the national early warning system and upgrading the hydro-met service to mitigate and adapt to the negative effects of climate change.⁹ According to the MTR report, the Bank will continue to take into account the environmental aspects in its projects, such as climate change mitigation, particularly droughts, and promoting the sustainable use of natural resources.

The validation noted that no ESW has been conducted due to the lack of dedicated funding.

⁹ Following the review of the MTR report and IPRs and discussions with the country team, it appears that these actions will be implemented during the remaining period of the CSP.

3.7. Overall Performance

3.7.1. Bank performance and its presence in the country

The overall performance of the Bank is assessed as satisfactory. At the time of writing the MTR report (September 2022), the Bank's performance was considered satisfactory, but with some challenges in the implementation of the portfolio due to COVID-19 lockdowns and travel restrictions. The Bank was unable to conduct physical project supervisions in Eswatini in 2020 and 2021, which adversely affected portfolio implementation, especially infrastructure projects. The MTR rates the portfolio at 3.0 (on scale 1-4, with 1 being highly unsatisfactory and 4 highly satisfactory), as in 2019. The validation agrees with this rating in view of the challenges encountered during the first phase of the CSP 2020-2024 implementation. As of 31 August 2022, the average age of the portfolio was 3.3 years, with a disbursement rate of 39.0 percent. The COVID-19 pandemic contributed to cost increases and delayed implementation.

Several factors slowing down the successful implementation of the portfolio are noted by the validation. These are, among others: (i) delays in project start-up attributed to the lengthy parliamentary approval and ratification of loan agreements; (ii) late commencement of civil works due to the unavailability of key international experts and imported construction materials due to COVID-19 lockdowns and travel restrictions; (iii) delays in procurement mainly due to the poor quality of project readiness, ineffective contract management and non-compliance with Procurement Plans by the PIUs; (iv) delays in releasing government counterpart funding; and (v) the lack of fully dedicated PIU staff.

The 2022 Portfolio Improvement Plan (PIP) noted several issues requiring attention by the Bank and the Government, which are mostly the same as listed above. With the Bank's new Liaison Office having been opened in September 2022, the validation considers that the rest of the actions proposed by the PIP remain relevant to improving the implementation of projects, such as: (i) strengthening the quality control of project design by the Government and the Bank; and (ii) targeted training and fiduciary workshops to address capacity gaps. However, the two actions not implemented from the CPIP 2019, i.e., (i) Develop Project implementation manual for all Bank Funded Projects; and (ii) Make sure the Project implementation timeframe is realistic and takes into account the country specific issues (such as the length of approval processes and authority delegation within the Government) have not been taken into account in the CPIP 2022. These issues (and related actions) remain relevant and constitute an obstacle to the proper implementation of the Bank's activities.

The validation notes that the intensification of dialogue with the opening of the Liaison Office has made it possible to make progress in the implementation of the strategy, particularly regarding disbursement and the adoption of projects by the country. However, the validation notes that most of the task managers are in the Regional Directorate General for Southern Africa (RDGS) regional office. Depending on the case, the deployment of additional staff in Eswatini could make it possible to further improve the monitoring and implementation of the projects.

3.7.2. Country Performance

Regarding Eswatini's performance, the MTR notes this as satisfactory, despite some adjustments that remain necessary, as shown by the CPIPs 2019 and 2022. The implementation status of the 2019 CPIP shows that progress has been made, for example, by: (i) holding at least two monthly tele/videoconferences with the PIUs, and an annual joint Bank/Government portfolio review meeting; and (ii) aligning procurement plans with project implementation plans. With the execution rate being 73 percent, efforts still need to be made for the full implementation of the plan. Some, but not all, remaining actions have been included in the 2022 CPIP. The COVID-19 outbreak in early 2020 and the resulting lockdowns and travel restrictions negatively impacted the projects' physical supervision, which delayed the implementation of the CPIP 2019. In view of this, the validation agrees with the MTR and considers the country's performance to be satisfactory.

On the economic side, the MTR notes progress in the Government's PFM reforms, although important measures remain to be taken, such as: (i) the new PFM regulations; (ii) the implementation of the Treasury Single Account; (iii) the introduction of an internal audit function; and (iv) a comprehensive roadmap for PFM. In addition, the Government's public deficit widened between 2020 and 2022, but the country's debt level remains sustainable.

The Government of Eswatini has developed a new NDP (2023-2027), which will maintain the priorities defined in the previous NDP 2019-2022. The strategic objectives of the NDP 2023-2027 are as follows:

- restoration of macroeconomic and fiscal sustainability;
- private sector development;
- social and human capital development;
- efficient public service delivery;
- well-managed natural resources and environmental sustainability, mitigating climate change, disaster risk management; and
- infrastructure development.

These objectives are in line with the Bank's actions in Eswatini under the CSP 2020-2024.

With regard to the monitoring of project activities, efforts have been made by the Ministry of Finance, which worked closely with the Bank to follow up on pending requests in order to accelerate portfolio implementation and resolve key issues that are hampering project delivery. With regard to disbursements, much progress still needs to be made, since the projects in the portfolio with substantial disbursements are mainly those of the CSP 2014-2018. Most of the approved CSP 2020-2024 projects are in the start-up phase, and the majority of the planned Indicative Operational Programs (IOPs) remain to be approved. The MTR, however, noted some problems related to compliance with prerequisites, the timely release of counterpart funds, and the quality of project design, which affects the procurement process and disbursements. Finally, the operationalization of the DCP is still work in progress. Ultimately, it is expected to make it possible to better coordinate the actions of the country's various partners through the Eswatini Development Cooperation Forum and Sector Working Groups.

According to the Country Fiduciary Risk Assessment (CFRA),¹⁰ the overall fiduciary risk to the Bank's interventions is assessed as substantial due to several components that are not functioning properly. With regard to PFM, the fiduciary risk analysis indicates that Eswatini's public finance strategy lacks credibility due to unrealistic budgets (significant differences between forecasts and actuals) and persistent problems that are exacerbated by expenditure arrears. This resulted in underspending of budgeted capital expenditure. With regard to the Treasury, according to the CFRA, there are delays in the implementation of the Treasury Single Account to improve overall cash management. In addition, the current Treasury system is centralized, and ministries, departments and agencies (MDAs) have very limited involvement in the forecasting process, which reduces the credibility and accuracy of forecasts. As for accounting and reporting, the current government accounting system uses outdated technology and lacks an accounts payable module. MDAs do not process sufficient information relating to the resources that they receive directly, bank reconciliations are not carried out regularly, and the reliability of accounting entries has been called into question on multiple occasions. The Treasury uses outdated data (previous year performance/requirements, and previous quarter instead of the updated quarterly cash flow forecasts) for cash flow forecasts, while accounting for donor projects is still done outside the Treasury Accounting System (TAS), with concurrent banking operations independent of the Treasury. Finally, the CRFA notes that there is no system to reconcile the completeness, validity and accuracy of information on loans and guarantees. With regard to internal controls, the fiduciary risk analysis finds that some control measures are applied through the TAS, but other types of recurrent expenses such as salaries, utilities, travel, and staff allowances are not included in the TAS and therefore not subject to effective controls.

4. ASSESSMENT OF THE QUALITY OF THE MID-TERM REVIEW

In general, the validation found the MTR report to be of good quality (see Annex 5). It tracks the progress made in the implementation of AfDB projects, as well as the state of the portfolio at mid-term. In addition, the MTR report presents a comprehensive description of the context in which the CSP is being implemented, which enables a deeper understanding of the challenges and impediments that have hampered the successful execution of the Bank's program in Eswatini. Furthermore, the report highlights the results accomplished through various interventions and describes the objectives set for the end of the CSP, as well as those already achieved at mid-term. The assessment provided by the MTR is based globally on evidence.

The combination of the MTR with the portfolio review allows the assessment of the main issues faced during program implementation.

¹⁰ Annex 12 of the MTR report: Summary of Country Fiduciary Risk Assessment (CFRA).

The validation considers the choice to continue with the same pillars of the CSP as relevant and its strategic orientations envisaged for the remainder of the period as appropriate. This is even more crucial since the challenges encountered during the preparation of the CSP are still present, and national priorities remain unchanged.

While the results framework in Annex 1 of the MTR effectively presents the mid-term results achieved by the CSP, this presentation could be further enhanced by better highlighting the expected results at mid-term and at the end of the CSP in a distinct way. This would improve the analysis and enable a more comprehensive assessment of the extent to which the expected mid-term results have been achieved. In this validation note, for lack of mid-term targets, a comparison has been made with the expected results at the end of the CSP.

5. STATUS OF IMPLEMENTATION OF ESWATINI CSP EVALUATION (2009-2018) RECOMMENDATIONS

In 2019, IDEV evaluated the CSPs for the Kingdom of Eswatini over the period 2009-2018. At the time of the evaluation, the Bank's portfolio comprised 16 interventions for a total of UA 179.4 million, of which five were approved during the 2009-2013 period and the remaining during the 2014-2018 period. The objective of the evaluation was twofold: (i) to assess the assistance of the Bank to the country through an analysis of development results from key interventions and the reasons underlying such results; and (ii) to learn from challenges and successes in order to provide lessons and recommendations to inform the design of the next CSP.

Based on the findings and lessons drawn from the performance of the two CSPs, the evaluation proposed five recommendations, and Bank Management committed to undertake 14 actions in response to the recommendations¹¹. This section presents the recommendations and their implementation status, using the qualifications Low, Moderate, Substantial, and High (see Annex 6 for the details of the assessment).

Recommendation 1: Enhance selectivity and portfolio design to enable the Bank to contribute to more effective and sustainable results in Eswatini.

Implementation status is rated Substantial. The two actions committed by Bank Management were completed with less than a year's delay. The actions taken by Bank Management and verified by IDEV are as follows:

- The Bank's CSP 2020-2024 for Eswatini was prepared during Q4 2019 and approved by the Board on 25 February 2020. The new CSP prioritized two areas, namely: (i) Scaling-Up Infrastructure Investments to Foster Economic Diversification; and (ii) Strengthening Economic Governance to Improve the Investment Climate. Under the new CSP, the Bank has prioritized critical infrastructure investments in transport and agriculture as the primary priority sectors, while energy and water and sanitation support as secondary tier sectors. The proposed interventions, with an indicative lending program of MUA 610, are large and designed with flexibility to respond to the country's needs.

Recommendation 2: Improve quality at entry, by assessing capacity building and institutional strengthening needs before undertaking investments.

Implementation status is rated High. The actions have been implemented on time. The actions taken by Bank Management and verified by IDEV are as follows:

¹¹ ADB/BD/WP/2019/60 Add.1

- In April 2022, the Bank undertook a dialogue mission to Eswatini led by the Deputy Director General. The mission engaged authorities in the Ministry of Finance, including the Minister and officials in charge of processing Bank loan agreements, including guarantees. Other stakeholders engaged included the Ministry of Economic Planning and Development (in charge of the capital budget) and project implementing entities. During the dialogue, the Bank and the Government agreed on concrete measures to eliminate or significantly reduce loan ratification delays experienced in the past. These measures are contained in the 2022 CPIP. The Bank intends to continuously engage the Government on all new upcoming projects.
- In addition, several actions have been undertaken, including: (i) a deep institutional assessment has accompanied all recently developed projects. For instance, the new transport projects have undertaken measures to ensure that all compensation of project-affected persons is conducted prior to the start of construction work; (ii) a fiduciary clinic held in June 2020 and follow-up sessions with individual PIUs held in Q1 2021; (iii) the Bank has also made efforts to ensure that all conditions precedent to entry into force are fulfilled on time and conducted launch workshops for all new projects; and (iv) all projects on the lending program and 2022 IOP have been developed close to the recommendations to ensure quality at entry. These include the PBO and the Mukhonvo-Nyavuma Agricultural Project Phases 1 and 2. All projects were developed following dialogue with both the Government and the cooperating partners.

Recommendation 3: Strengthen the focus on managing for development results by monitoring and evaluating outputs, outcomes, and impacts, and assisting project coordination through sustained dialogue with other stakeholders.

Implementation status is rated Substantial. The committed action was completed with less than a year's delay. The actions implemented by Bank Management and verified by IDEV are as follows:

- The CSP (2020-2024) approved in February 2020 includes a monitoring and evaluation system that was reviewed and endorsed by the Development Impact and Results Department (SNDR). The presence of 92 percent of the task managers in the RDGS strengthened direct and ongoing advisory support to projects. However, the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic in early 2020, and the resultant lockdowns and travel restrictions, negatively impacted on physical supervision of projects, which delayed the implementation of the 2019 CPIP.

Recommendation 4: Safeguard development benefits by examining and improving operation and maintenance systems for all infrastructure interventions.

Implementation status is rated Substantial. Below are the actions implemented by Bank Management and verified by IDEV:

- The Government has put in place a mechanism for full recovery of the operation and maintenance costs, and this is expected to contribute significantly towards the sustainability of the transport sector projects. In addition, several reforms have been undertaken with the support of the Bank, including the transformation and operationalization of the Road Maintenance Fund. The Government is also working on a 10-year Road Investment and Maintenance Management Program (RIMMP) to strengthen asset preservation, guided by the country's Transport Master Plan (2013-2032).
- In the agriculture sector, the Government plans to create an agricultural fund to support the sustainability of agricultural projects.
- In the water sector, the design of the Mkondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program is supported by a feasibility study that addresses issues of project sustainability. The Mkondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase 1 is the only approved investment project to date since the new CSP 2020-2024 integrated measures that ensure project sustainability.

Recommendation 5: Enhance policy dialogue and knowledge management in the country assistance framework, to enhance its influence on the reform agenda and its catalytic potential.

Implementation status is rated Moderate. Three actions are still ongoing with delays, and two actions are completed with delays. However, the remaining actions can be considered almost completed.

through other Bank operations and activities. Below are the actions implemented by Bank Management and verified by IDEV:

- The Bank's engagement in policy dialogue continued and intensified during the COVID-19 pandemic. Working with other partners, a coordination mechanism emerged that should carry out the dialogue going forward.
- Due to resource constraints, it has not been possible to provide the envisaged targeted PPP support. However, Eswatini has been provided support by the African Legal Support Facility (ALSF) towards regulatory reforms. In addition, under the budget support operation approved by the Board in 2021, the Bank is pursuing broader support to private sector reforms, including dialogue on PPPs.
- The Public Procurement Technical Assistance is also expected to help to enhance the policy dialogue. The Eswatini Gender Profile was allocated a budget in the 2022 programming cycle and is almost completed.

6. CONCLUSIONS AND LESSONS

6.1. Conclusion

The validation notes that several factors have slowed down the successful implementation of the first phase of the CSP, both country-internally (political and social situation), at the Bank level (delays from approval to first disbursement, lack of budget for ESWs, etc.) and externally (the COVID-19 pandemic). The impact was substantial on portfolio investment projects.

The validation finds the Priority Areas of the CSP to be aligned with the country's development priorities and also aligned with the Bank's strategies, including the TYS and High 5s. The internal coherence and synergy of the Bank's portfolio of activities in Eswatini and the coherence with the activities of other development partners are considered as satisfactory. In terms of effectiveness, the validation assigned a partly unsatisfactory rating, despite notable progress compared with the findings of the last IDEV evaluation in 2019. For projects approved during the previous CSP, tangible results have been observed but are judged insufficient to achieve the objectives set by the CSP 2020-2024. For the current CSP, a number of planned operations have not yet been approved, and most of the major investment projects approved are still in the start-up phase, with their outputs and outcomes not yet realized. Finally, the scope of some projects has been reduced due to design problems. Therefore, the program is unlikely to achieve its expected results. The efficiency of AfDB interventions in Eswatini is also considered as partly unsatisfactory by the validation. Indeed, significant delays were reported in the implementation of projects, as illustrated by the low disbursement rates and the need for multiple extensions. However, there is progress compared with 2019. Delays can be attributed to the Bank (design and quality-at-entry issues), the Government (delays in project ratification) and external factors beyond stakeholders' control (the COVID-19 pandemic). Sustainability is deemed satisfactory. The sustainability of the Bank's operations has been strengthened over time due to the consideration of the sustainability of projects with regard to the challenges and risks that they may face (maintenance, capacity building, etc.) and the major reforms that are underway, particularly in the transport sector. Finally, the Bank plans to contribute to knowledge management activities by conducting studies such as the Eswatini Gender Profile and the African Economic Outlook (AEO) Country Notes for 2020, 2021 and 2022. However, no ESW has been conducted so far due to unavailability of funding.

The Bank's presence in Eswatini since September 2022 was found to contribute to improving policy dialogue by proximity, while offering it the opportunity for better coordination with other development partners in Eswatini. Regarding the continuation of the CSP, the validation judged the decision to maintain the pillars of the CSP as justified in view of the challenges that Eswatini faces, and which remain the same.

The quality of the MTR was generally deemed satisfactory by the validation.

6.2. Lessons

The MTR draws both strategic and operational lessons from the mid-term implementation of the CSP. The validation reviewed these lessons and identified additional lessons.

Strategic Lessons

- (i) It is necessary to intensify the dialogue with the private sector, and design tailored and innovative financing instruments to strengthen the role of the Bank in the development of the private sector and to meet the specific needs of Eswatini.

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant but proposes the following reformulation: “Intensifying dialogue with the private sector coupled with designing tailored and innovative financing instruments strengthens the role of the Bank in the development of the private sector to meet the needs of Eswatini.”

Lessons at the Operational Level

- (ii) The need to give particular attention to project preparation (quality and scope of design) in order to improve projects’ quality at entry and reduce delays related to procurement.

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant but proposes the following reformulation: “Strong project preparation (quality and scope of design) improves quality at entry and hence reduces delays related to procurement.”

- (iii) Ensuring the timely disbursement of counterpart financing to avoid implementation delays and cost increases.

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant but proposes the following reformulation: “Timely disbursement of counterpart financing reduces implementation delays and cost increases.”

- (iv) Key staff of the PIUs must be fully dedicated to the project (especially transport and water supply projects).

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant but proposes the following reformulation to highlight the targeted outcome: “Key (PIU) staff fully dedicated to the projects for which they are in charge improve project management and reduce delays.”

- (v) Ensuring the use of tracking tools (such as procurement plans and contract registers) to facilitate contract monitoring and management, as well as triggering timely contract extensions.

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant but proposes the following reformulation: “Use of tracking tools (such as procurement plans and contract registers) facilitates contract monitoring and management as well as triggering timely contract extensions.” Indeed, capacity building usually focuses more on mastering these different tools.

- (vi) Increasing the frequency of regular virtual meetings with the PIUs to provide them with consistent guidance on procurement and financial management issues.

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant. Now that travel restrictions have been lifted, these meetings could also be held in person.

- (vii) Continuing targeted training during supervision missions and fiduciary workshops address capacity gaps (including lack of mastery of the Bank’s rules and procedures, non-compliance with procurement plans, limited knowledge of contract management, dispute resolution, and financial management).

Review comment on this lesson: The validation considers this lesson relevant.

6.3. Additional Lessons from the Validation

Through the validation note, IDEV provides additional lessons to continue the achievement of Eswatini’s development objectives:

- (i) An adequate monitoring and evaluation of the implementation and the mid-term results requires clearly defined outputs and outcome targets at mid-term.
- (ii) The lack of clear rating of the various criteria (relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, etc.) in the MTR makes validation difficult.

- (iii) Failure to sufficiently take into account the risk of inflation and/or the risk of depreciation in the financing of projects in local currencies may generate additional costs, possibly leading to delays and/or the partial (or total) cancellation of projects. It is important to reconcile the management of the inflationary risk of imports with the desire of the government to take loans in local currency in order to reduce the exchange risk of Swaziland Lilangeni indexed to the South African Rand (which is very volatile).
- (iv) The Bank would benefit from greater realism in defining project implementation timeframes (such as the length of approval processes and delegation of authority within the Government).

7. ANNEXES

ANNEX 1: Summary Table of Expected Versus Actual Outcomes/Outputs

Performance Area	Monitoring Indicators	Baseline (2018)	Actual Mid-Term Achievements (2022)	Target (2024)	Data Source
Operational Results from Projects (including carried over projects from CSP 2014-2018)	Agriculture Export with value addition of local primary products (%)	32	32	36	MoA Annual Report, Labour Force Survey MCIT & Industry
	Transport Traffic accidents (per 1,000 vehicles)				Performance Reports/Annual Reports, ESR Reports/MPWT
	Capacity of Eswatini railways network (metric tons)	1054	554	404	
	Energy (Electricity) Access to electricity (% of population)	78	82	87	MNRE, ESERA, EEC
	Renewable energy generation (MW)	177	192.7	195	
	Water and Sanitation Access to improved water supply (% of pop)	69	71	80	EWSC Statistics & Annual Report, Water Point Mapping Report
	Access to improved sanitation facilities (% of pop)	46	64	75	
	Economic Governance Fiscal deficits (% of GDP)	6.5%	6.4%	< 3%	Budget Estimates, CBE, IMF Reports, TI
	National budgets alignment to NDPs	No	Yes	Yes	
	Transparency International Corruption Perception Index (Ranking)	89	122	<80	
Outcomes	Private Sector Development Doing Business Ranking	117	121	<110	World Bank Reports
	Agriculture Irrigation systems constructed (km)	0	39	39	ESWADE Reports
	No. of value chains developed	0	0	2	
	Transport Roads constructed, upgraded, rehabilitated (km)	260	600	11540	EASY WE progress reports
	Railroad upgraded (km)				
	Energy Renewable energy sources installed (MW)	0	0	113	Project implementation reports
	Water and Sanitation Volume of water produced (m ³ /d)	7,680	7,680	32,000	
	Sewerage reticulation built	15,000	77,000	61,000	ESERA, EEC
	Economic Governance Fiscal adjustment strategy and action plan adopted	No	Yes	Yes	EWSC Reports, Progress Reports, Supervision Mission Reports
	Domestic arrears clearance strategy implemented	No	Yes	Yes	
Outputs (Outputs from projects proposed in CSP)	PFM Roadmap implemented	No	No	Yes	Project Implementation Reports, CRFA IMF Article IV Reports
	Private Sector Development PPP policy and legislative framework further developed	No	No	Yes	Project implementation reports

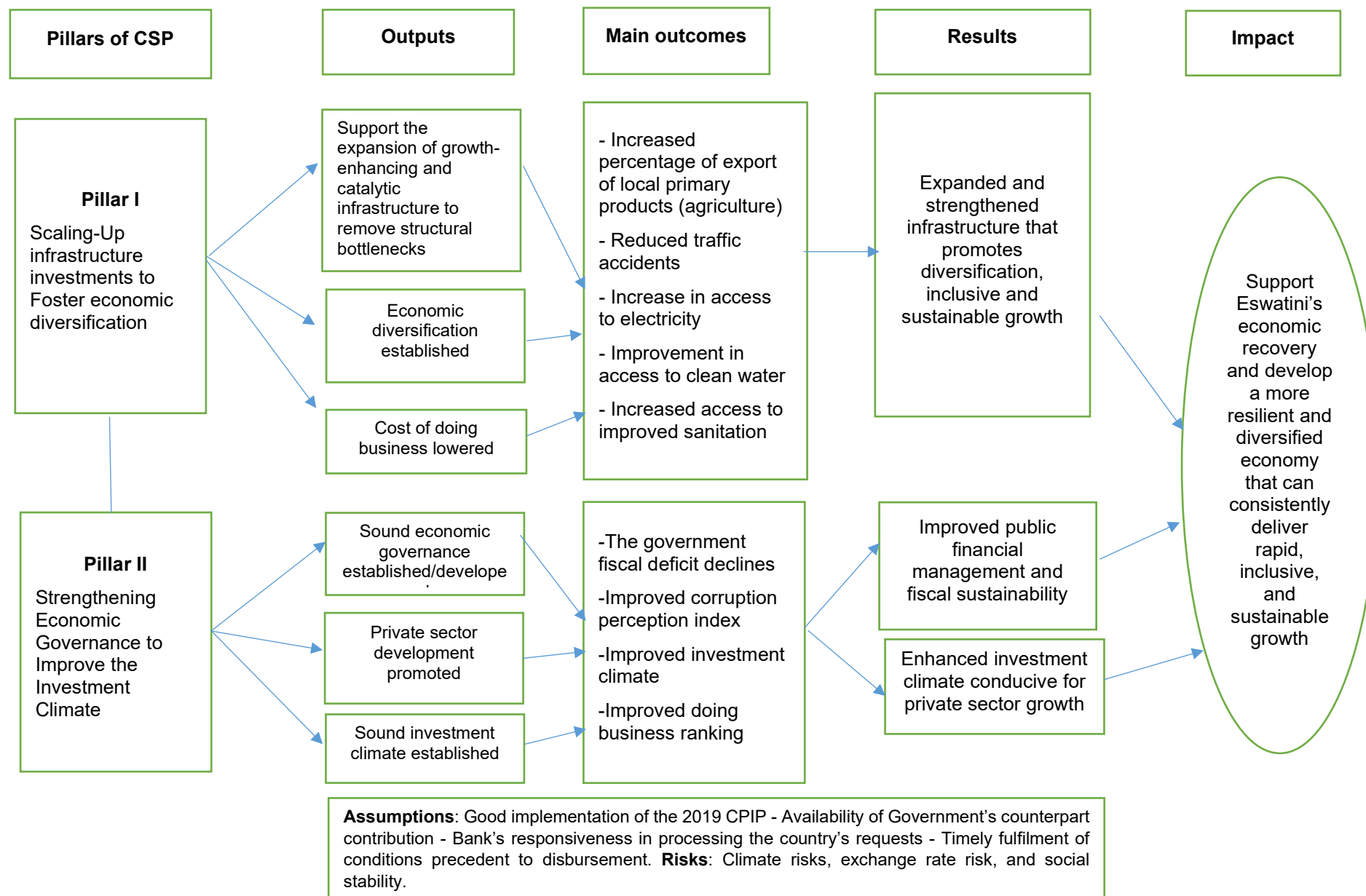
Cross-cutting (Climate change, gender, youth)	Outcome: Country Nationally Determined Contributions (NDC) (climate resilience and vulnerability) index improved (Ranking) Outcome: Improvement in Gender Inequality Index (UNDP) Output: Improved sustainable livelihoods and climate resilience (% of population) Output: Female owned MSMEs with access to financing from formal institutions (%)	Medium 0.57 11 6	 0.57	Medium 0.50 30 15	Climate Change Risk Profile-Southern Africa; Annual Vulnerability Assessment & Analysis Report UNDP HDR FinScope Surveys
Policy advice and Knowledge	- Identifying Opportunities for Unlocking Growth study - Fiscal Consolidation Plan adopted	No No	No Yes	Yes Yes	Publication of the studies PFM reform policies adopted
Financial Leveraging	- Co-financing and parallel financing (UA million) - PPP transactions (#)	0	0 0	1	Project Appraisal Reports
Portfolio performance	- Average Gender Marker rating for projects (1 to 4) - Average QaE rating (1 to 4) - Average IPR rating (1 to 4) - Timely completed PCRs (days) - Disbursement ratio (%)	3 3 3 100 40	3	2 3 3.5 100 75	QaE Readiness Review IPR Reports/CPPR PCR Dashboard Portfolio Flashlight Report
Sustainability and capacity building	Fiduciary clinics undertaken (#)	1	1	3	BTOR
Development coordination and harmonization	- Sector Working Groups chaired by the Bank (#) - Sector Working Groups participated in by the Bank (#)	0 1	0 1	1 2	BTORs

ANNEX 2: Projects analyzed in the MTR Validation of Eswatini

Project Code	Project Title	Commitment in UA	Starting Date	Status	Sector	Sovereign/Non-sovereign
P-SZ-A00-006	Eswatini - Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program, Phase I, Part B (MNWAP-1B)	91 512 155,29	16 Dec. 2022	Approved	Agriculture and Rural Development	Sovereign
P-SZ-KZ0-001	Eswatini - Public Procurement Technical Assistance	110 000,00	29 July 2022	Approved	Multi-Sector	Sovereign
P-SZ-AA0-013	Eswatini - Emergency Food Production Program (EFPP)	30 056 205,10	14 July 2022	Approved	Agriculture and Rural Development	Sovereign
P-SZ-K00-007	Eswatini-Support to state owned enterprises reforms in Eswatini	150 000,00	16 June 2022	Approved	Multi-Sector	Sovereign
P-SZ-A00-005	Eswatini - Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program Phase IA (MNWAP-1A)	86 049 814,42	17 Dec. 2021	Approved	Agriculture and Rural Development	Sovereign
P-SZ-K00-005	Eswatini - Support for Economic Recovery and Inclusive Growth (SERIG) Phase I	27 356 246,72	24 Nov. 2021	Implementation	Multi-Sector	Sovereign
P-SZ-AA0-007	Eswatini - Mkhondvo-Ngwavuma Water Augmentation Program (MNWAP) Study	1 200 000,00	30 March 2020	Implementation	Agriculture and Rural Development	Sovereign
P-SZ-EA0-003	Eswatini - Manzini Region Water Supply and Sanitation Project	32 246 212,85	29 Nov. 2018	Implementation	Water Supply & Sanitation	Sovereign

P-SZ-DB0-013	Eswatini - Development of Manzini Golf Course Interchange	29 956 873,74	24 Oct. 2018	Implementation	Transport	Sovereign
P-SZ-HAA-001	Swaziland - Swaziland Development Finance Corporation (FINCORP) - Second LoC is under the Africa SME Program	9 561 978,25	12 May 2017	Implementation	Finance	Non-Sovereign
P-SZ-AAC-005	Swaziland - Lower Usuthu Smallholders Irrigation Project II	35 551 060,96	04 May 2016	Implementation	Agriculture and Rural Development	Sovereign
P-SZ-EAZ-001	Swaziland - NONDVO multipurpose dam feasibility study	1 336 638,70	21 Dec. 2015	Completion	Water Supply & Sanitation	Sovereign
P-SZ-EAZ-002	Swaziland- Mbabane Manzini corridor (Nondvo) multipurpose dam study	797 416,00	21 Dec. 2015	Completion	Water Supply & Sanitation	Sovereign
P-SZ-E00-005	Swaziland - Ezulwini Sustainable Water Supply and Sanitation Service Delivery Project	17 292 086,20	18 June 2014	Implementation	Water Supply & Sanitation	Sovereign
P-SZ-DB0-012	Swaziland - Manzini to Mbadlane (MR3) Highway Project	53 520 836,26	28 May 2014	Implementation	Transport	Sovereign

ANNEX 3: Theory of Change



ANNEX 4: Four-point Rating Scale

Scale	1 Unsatisfactory	2 Partly Unsatisfactory	3 Satisfactory	4 Highly Satisfactory
Relevance	Very weak, not at all appropriate design and very limited/non-existent alignment.	Weak, improper design and limited alignment/several gaps.	Rather strong and appropriate design, strong alignment.	Very solid and appropriate design, perfect alignment.
Coherence	- Perfect support, synergies and interconnections. - Very weak complementarity, harmonization and coordination with other operations.	- Perfect support, synergies and interconnections. - Very weak complementarity, harmonization and coordination with other operations.	- Perfect support, synergies and interconnections. - Modest complementarity, harmonization and coordination with other operations.	- Very strong support and perfect synergies and interconnections. - Very solid complementarity, harmonization and coordination with other operations.
Effectiveness	- Expected outputs not achieved in most cases. - None or very few of the expected outcomes are achieved.	- Expected outputs achieved with significant gaps. - Few targeted outcomes are achieved.	- Expected outputs are achieved in most cases. - Most of the targeted outcomes are achieved.	- Expected outputs are fully achieved. - All targeted outcomes are achieved.
Efficiency	Very significant gap between planned and actual implementation schedule.	Significant gap between planned and actual implementation schedule.	Moderate gap between planned and actual implementation schedule.	Little or no difference between planned and actual implementation schedule.
Sustainability	Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are not assured.	Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are hindered by significant risks.	Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are generally assured, with some minor risks.	Mechanisms guaranteeing sustainability (technical, economic, financial, institutional, partnership, environmental and social) are fully ensured.

ANNEX 5: Mid-Term Review Quality Assessment Sheet

Criteria	Rating (1-4)***	Explanation/Comments
QUALITY OF THE MID-TERM REVIEW		
1. Degree and quality of completeness of evidence and analysis of the mid-term review to support the ratings of the different sections.	3	Evidence has been reported to support the mid-term analysis comprehensively. These elements justify the judgment made on the performance of the implementation of the CSP at mid-term.
2. Level of objectivity of the MTR evaluation ratings.	3	The objectivity of the MTR with regard to the achievement of results is judged sufficient by the validation. However, the MTR did not rate the criteria (relevance, effectiveness, etc.).
3. Degree of internal consistency of the evaluation ratings of the MTR Note; inaccuracies; inconsistencies (in different sections) between texts and ratings; consistency between the overall rating and the ratings of the various components.	2	In the absence of clear rating of the criteria in the MTR, it was difficult for the validation to judge.
4. Degree of identification and assessment of key factors (internal and exogenous) and unexpected effects (positive and negative) that affected the design and implementation of the CSP at mid-term.	3	The MTR notes the elements that disrupted the implementation of the program (COVID-19, procurement, political environment, etc.). Similarly, internal and exogenous factors are noted.
5. Adequacy of treatment of safeguard measures, fiduciary issues, alignment and harmonization, cross-sectoral aspects, factors of fragility and resilience.	2	These questions are dealt with in the MTR mainly in the Annexes.
6. Degree of robustness of the processes for generating and analyzing evidence (including results and performance indicators) in support of the evaluation of the MTR report.	3	Degree of solidity confirmed and corresponds to those observed in the progress and mission reports.
7. Overall adequacy of accessibility of evidence (from MTR Note, including annexes and other data provided).	3	The evidence was generally accessible through the IPRs which were available
8. To what extent lessons (and recommendations) are clear and based on the MTR assessment and reviews (evidence and analysis).	3	The lessons in the mid-term review are sufficiently consistent with the situations of the projects. However, the wording of the lessons needs to be improved to avoid them appearing like recommendations.
9. Degree of clarity and overall completeness of the MTR Note.	3	In general, the MTR clearly traced the situation on the degree of implementation of AfDB projects.
Others (to be specified)	N/A	
RATING ON THE QUALITY OF THE MID-TERM REVIEW NOTE	3	The report is overall satisfactory, and it highlights the difficulties encountered in the implementation of the projects and the lessons drawn
Compliance of the MTR Note with operational guidelines (Operations Manual, etc.)		
1. MTR Note delivery times (On time = 4; late = 1)	4	The MTR Note was delivered on time, in October 2022.

2. Degree of participation of the Borrower, Co-financiers and Regional and Country Offices in the preparation of the MTR Note	2	The degree of participation of the Regional Office and the country team in the drafting of the MTR is appreciable. No mention is made of the participation by the borrower or co-financiers.
3. Other aspects (to be specified)	N/A	
Rating on compliance of the MTR	3	Overall, the MTR is compliant, with a lot of relevant information analyzed. However, it would have been good to see the expected results at mid-term in the CSP results matrix; it currently only contains the expected results at the end of the CSP.
*** Rated High/exemplary (4), or substantial/significant (3), or moderate (2), or negligible (1)		

ANNEX 6: Management Action Plans Assessment Template

MARS Independent Assessment of the Level of Adoption of IDEV's Recommendations								
Evaluation Title								
Date of CODE								
Assessment Date								
		General Information					Guide for Completing Template	
Recommendation Code								
Recommendation		Key indicators that capture the essence of the recommendation	Actions (Management Response)	Key indicators that capture the essence of the action	Target Completion Date	Completion Date or last update (in not completed)	Responsible Department	Please use the evaluation document and the management response to fill these boxes. Ensure that the key indicators expected from the implementation of the recommendation are well identified.
1		Level of Alignment						
		Low / Moderate / Substantial / High/	Explanations				Assessment Criteria	
	To what extent the committed actions in the Management Response are aligned with the agreed recommendations of IDEV?						High (4): Very solid alignment of all committed actions with the recommendation. Substantial (3): Strong alignment of most of the committed actions with minor shortcomings. Moderate (2): Limited alignment of most of the committed actions with the recommendation. Low (1): Very weak or non-existent alignment of most of the committed actions with the recommendation.	
2		Level of Implementation						
		Low / Moderate / Substantial / High/ NA	Evidence provided by Management				Assessment Criteria	

	To what extent the committed actions have been implemented as planned?							High (4): If all actions have been completed as planned (on time). Substantial (3): If most of the actions have been completed no later than one (01) year after the target completion date. Moderate (2): If most of the actions have been completed with a delay greater than one (01) year but less than two (02) years Or are ongoing with a delay less than one (01) years. Low (1): If most of the action have been completed with a delay greater than or equal to two (02) years Or are ongoing with a delay greater than or equal to one (01) years Or the management did not provide enough evidence on the implementation of the actions.
3		Level of Adoption* =Level of Alignment + Level of Implementation						
		Low / Moderate / Substantial / High/ NA		Explanation				Assessment Criteria
	To what extent the recommendation has been adopted?							High (4): if level of alignment AND level of implementation are rated High Substantial (3): if level of alignment AND level of implementation are rated at least Substantial Moderate (2): if level of alignment AND level of implementation are rated at least Moderate Low (1): if level of alignment OR level of implementation are rated is Low

*The level of adoption relies on both the level of alignment and the level of implementation. For a recommendation to be adopted the two conditions must be simultaneously met. For example, a recommendation is considered weakly adopted when the action is highly aligned with the recommendation but has not been implemented because the problem raised by the recommendation remains unresolved and no progress can be expected. Similarly, a recommendation will be considered weakly adopted if the action is weakly aligned with the recommendation, even if it is fully implemented, because the action is unsuitable, and the problem will remain. Therefore, the level of adoption is not just an average of the ratings of the level of alignment and the level of implementation.